myself on a diet of nothing but tea without sugar, boiled *chana* (chickpeas), oranges and sweet lime. I also started doing some rigorous exercise again to get back into shape. I used to run for an hour in the morning, followed by weight training, and played two hours of table-tennis every evening. And during the table-tennis sessions I'd go and fetch the ball from wherever it went. Even if I had played a smash and the ball had gone behind my opponent, I'd perform the chore myself, to get more exercise. The result was a weight loss of 10 kg in twenty days. But I had started to feel dizzy and weak and my trousers were now too loose, so I decided it was time to stop. The first meal I had after three weeks on the diet was boiled spinach and broccoli and after that I went back to eating normally.

The perfect partner

To come from such a different background and yet be able to integrate herself into the more traditional Tendulkar household speaks volumes for Anjali's character and commitment. Frankly, no credit can be enough for her. She was an exceptional student and could have had an exceptional career. But she decided to stand by me and has been with me every moment over the past two decades and more. There have been occasions when I have been away from home and haven't seen my kids, Sara and Arjun, for months. For example, soon after the 2011 World Cup I suddenly realized that I hadn't noticed that Arjun was almost my height. (He is in fact taller than me now.) There is no doubt I have missed out on some really precious moments with my family. Such separations are part of a professional sportsman's life, of course, but I was only able to get through them because I always knew Anjali was there.

At the same time, I knew Anjali appreciated why I was away and was proud of what I was doing. She is the one person I can turn to at all times, for whatever she says is always in my best interests. Not only has she given me critical feedback on key decisions; she has taken care of everything on the domestic front. Starting with the kids, my mother, extended family, finances and a host of other issues, with Anjali in control I could focus on playing cricket. She is also my emotional rock, someone I turn to at every moment of self-doubt. There has never been any pressure on me to return home early from my engagements, for Anjali has always insisted that I should get back home only after I have